China never frontally confronted the United States, which was the bigger power. It worked through the strong American non-proliferation lobby and the American think-tank community. China has, over the years, developed strong networks through its think-tanks and academics, with people in the United States who can influence US policy, including in the administration, in Congress and in the media. The Chinese think-tanks flatter them by giving the impression that by engaging with Chinese academicians, they are gaining insight into Chinese thinking. As a result, senior Chinese academics have had greater access to policy-making circles in America than those from India or any other major developing country. The lack of reciprocal access at the official level in China even for the United States makes the Chinese think-tanks a potent force multiplier in the Chinese negotiating arsenal. It speaks for China, but this is deniable if it suits the Chinese government. That way there is less pressure for China to make its official position explicit until it is fully aware of the state-of-play. It was only after the strenuous efforts by the Chinese think-tanks to influence the non-proliferation lobby, the members of Congress and the media had failed in putting a stop to the Indo–US nuclear deal, that the Chinese government stepped out from behind the curtain. These were early days for China's membership of the NSG, and the final result fell short of their expectations. For India it is a lesson on the Chinese negotiating tactic of remaining in the shadows, performing the role of puppet-master until it is absolutely required to take a stand.

China also exhibited its capacity for multi-layered diplomacy. It flattered the smaller NSG members by making them feel that the bigger powers, especially the United States, did not care for their opinions. Many of these countries were still smarting from the manner in which Americans had bullied them during the invasion of Iraq. The Chinese saw this as an opportunity to